stand up for my beliefs. But the profound love he had for Rahul ji left me in tears. I was so proud to follow a man who could inspire such devotion.

I just have to think back to what I saw in Marthandam in Kerala and in Rajasthan. As we entered the town's embrace, we were greeted with the eruption of a powerful roar, which shook the ground long after we walked by. We were swept up in a tidal wave of chants of 'Rahul ... Rahul ... Rahul …' I am from Tamil Nadu, where people go deliriously mad when they see celebrities such as Rajinikanth, Jayalalithaa and Kamal Haasan. So I'm used to frenzies. But I have never seen that kind of adulation and love. You had to be there to believe it. Earlier, whenever I saw any post from the Sanghi ecosystem suggesting that Rahul Gandhi was not a popular leader or something equally nonsensical, I used to get very worked up. Now I just remember Marthandam and chuckle to myself. I don't think any of us will get fazed any more and deal with them easily.

Struggles and Succour

But it was not all hope and idealism and boundless energy. It was hard work and sacrifice and pain. Even though it was the sweet voice of Pyari Jaan (a Bharat yatri from Karnataka who would sing the morning prayer every day before the Yatra) that awakened us every day, it was at 3.30 a.m.! Even though I always found it amusing to be greeted in various Indian languages, it was over breakfast at 5 a.m.! And even though my heart was full of pride to see my Tricolour every morning, the flag hoisting was at 5.15 a.m. The Yatra began at 5.45 a.m. and continued till 7 p.m. every day! The discipline we all had to follow rigorously for six months was extraordinary. It was very strenuous.

So one day, during lunch, Rahul Gandhi surprised some of us yatris by joining us for a casual discussion. Others talked about lofty ideas, but I didn't want to waste the chance. So before anyone could object, I suggested, 'Why don't we walk a more manageable 10 kilometres? Twenty-five kilometres is a lot per day.' Rahul ji was so surprised that he burst out